

AN OS YOU WANT!

Agent 001

I've sort of patented a term here at Digit, because I have the habit of saying "Ooh, I want!" when I see a really cool or geeky product. Anyway, long story short, the idea for this article came about when my editor, getting a little fed up of hearing "I want", asked me, "So what is it that you really want?" I was shell-shocked. Why? You'd understand better if you thought of my editor as a rich parent, and me as a kid in a candy or toy store being asked that same question. "Why, everything of course," was my reply.

After shaking his head for a few seconds and making the dissenting noises only he can, he reiterated, "No. I mean, what is it that you *really* want from technology? For example, suppose you owned every tech company on Earth; what is the first product you will get everyone to start building for you?"

I just stood there, mouth agape. Obviously I understood where this was headed, and I knew exactly what he meant, but I was already far, far away in fantasy-land, too busy building castles out of hundred-dollar notes. Well it was his fault for putting it that way, "owned *every* tech company on Earth" indeed!

He snapped his fingers and promptly dragged me out of fantasy world, "Well?" he asked impatiently. After the cogs in my head were done whirring, I said, "The perfect OS". He turned, walked away, and his voice trailed behind, "Write it; about 2400 words; deadline next week..."

Why Not The World's Fastest PC?

A lot of my buddies asked me why I didn't think of this. To be honest, I would like to be the first person on Earth to run an 80-core, 10 GHz, 2 TB RAM machine, but then again, what would I run *on* it? Vista or Ubuntu? Hell no! What would be the point of all that hardware if it gave me not much of a difference in experience than what my quad-core with 4 gigs of RAM and GTX 280 offer me already?

It's always been a lot easier for all of us at Digit to criticise and complain about certain missing features, or bugs in code. However, while sitting and thinking of my "FutureOS", I realised how hard it is to come up with ideas for those killer features that would set my OS apart from everything else out there. Hats off to all of the software and hardware developers out there who bring us so many exciting products—if I was having such a tough time coming up with imaginary features, imagine their plight of having to not only think them up, but implement them as well!

Rather than sit around waiting to see what a future operating system (OS) will offer, we're preparing our own wish list. Let's just hope that the powers that be are listening...

Coolness

Let's face it; everyone seems to be gravitating towards being cool-looking. Everyone associates Apple with "cool", and rightly so. Their MacOS started the *pretty-looking-OS* revolution, and Linux and Vista just seemed to have played follow-the-leader. So now we have Aero and whatnot offering us fancy 3D effects for mundane tasks like Alt-Tabbing—forgive me if I don't faint like a young girl at a Michael Jackson concert.

Now I'm no Vista-hater, because I'm running it, and without an anti-virus at that, for almost a year without any problems. It's quite obvious to me that Microsoft coders have done an excellent job with the security...well, either that or virus and worm writers have all fallen asleep...

However, there are just some things I just cannot seem to get used to. Take for example the fact that I have to go through 2 or 3 screens just to change my screen resolution, IP, gateway or DNS server. All of this was just a click away in XP, and sometimes you can't help but want it back.

As for Linux, I've seen Beryl and XGL/Compiz, and they're just as pretty. Apple has Aqua, and its animation effects are cute, and personally, I prefer it to the rest because it's not so over-the-top as the others. However, all this rush to make pretty OSes has me thinking that we're certainly headed down the wrong path here. Personally, if you saw my system, you would think it runs on XP, because I've got Vista running without all the eye-candy. Does it really matter to me that windows are not translucent, or Alt-Tabbing doesn't bring up cool animated 3D effects? It certainly hasn't affected my work, or the fun I have when using my computer.

What irritates me is the fact that some of my relatives, who might still be using Windows 98 at home, come over and want to see "Aero in action". It's not the added security, it's not the robustness of the kernel...it's the *damn gimmicks* they like. Sadly, that's the world we live in today, where *bling* sells, and reliability doesn't matter. Thankfully, Windows 7 promises to not just bring prettiness to the screen, but a revolution in terms of interfacing with technology. Even if it isn't the best, at least it's a step in the right direction.

Interfaces

We've all being going ga-ga over the iPhone, and with good reason too. Without getting into debates such as whether the iPhone 3G is really worth its price tag, especially in India—where we're sometimes struggling to get 2G services to work satisfactorily—let's give it the credit it deserves for revolutionising mobile interfaces. Similarly, Windows 7 promises to change the way we interface with the common PC, by adding